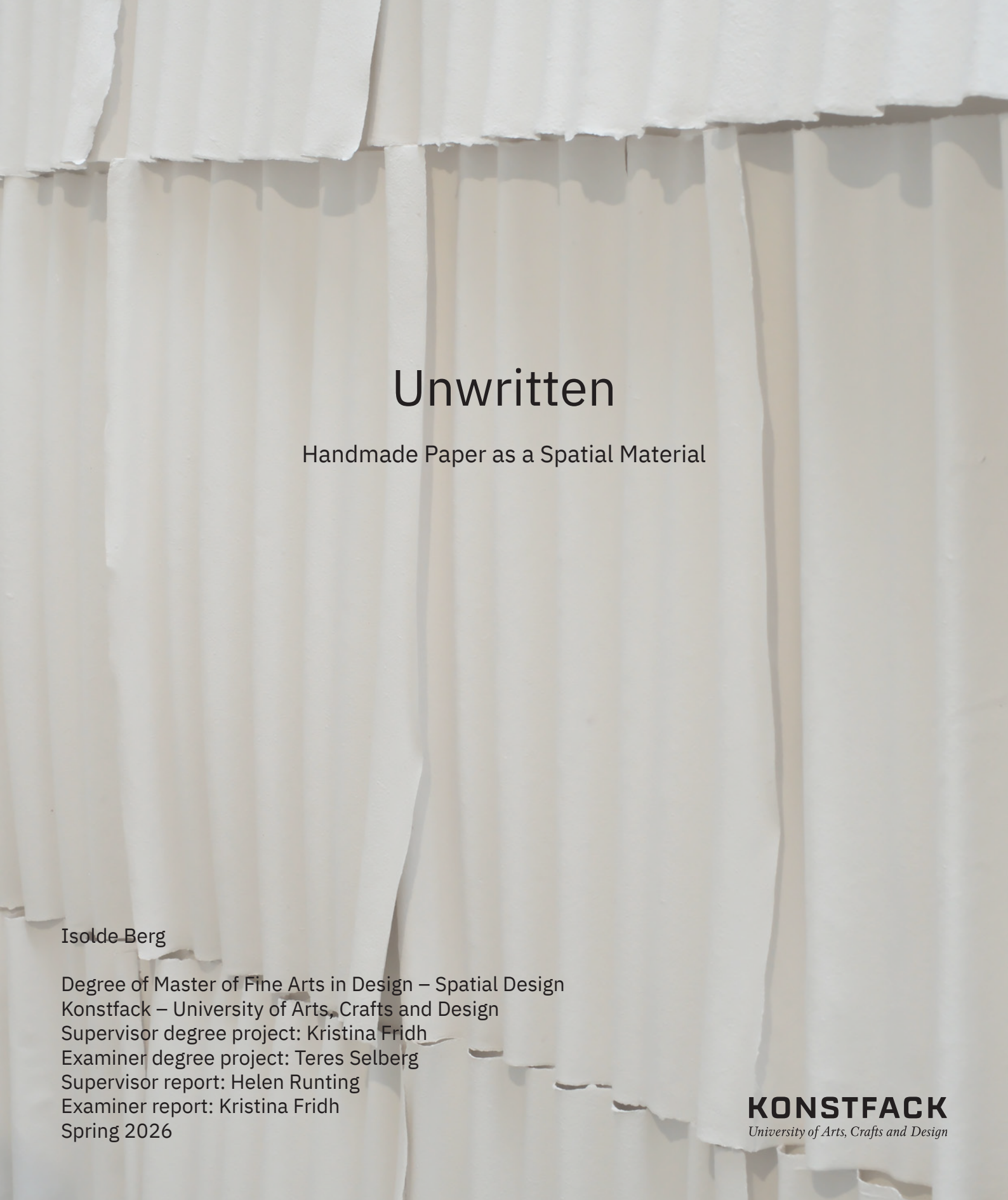


Unwritten

Handmade Paper as a Spatial Material

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Abstract

This degree project investigates handmade paper as a spatial material within interior architecture. Through a practice-based design process, the project explores how handmade paper—through its tactile qualities, structural behavior, and embedded craft knowledge — can generate alternative spatial expressions compared to industrially standardized materials.

The project originates from both a material curiosity and a personal connection to Lessebo Handpappersbruk in Sweden, located approximately 35 kilometers from the city where I grew up. This proximity created an early awareness of handmade paper as a living craft tradition and raised questions about its relevance within spatial design.

To explore this, the project combines field studies, material experimentation, and spatial prototyping. A field study in Japan examined traditional and contemporary applications of *washi* in architecture and interiors. These observations were combined with practical experiments at Lessebo Handpappersbruk in Sweden, where paper pulp was explored beyond the traditional flat sheet and instead treated as a sculptural material.

Through CNC-milled molds, fiber testing, drying experiments, and sheet manipulation, a series of techniques were developed that allowed paper to function as structure, volume, surface, and enclosure.

The final project consists of three spatial objects: a room divider, lighting fixtures, and a cabinet. Each object demonstrates a different way of working with handmade paper as a spatial material. Together, they investigate how craft traditions, material-led experimentation, and slower production processes can contribute to new expressions within interior architecture.

Thank you to Lessebo Handpappersbruk for welcoming me so warmly into both the mill and the production process, and for answering all of my questions. Thank you for allowing me to experiment and play.

A special thank you as well to my uncle, Roy Johnson, for all the oak from Blidingsholm.

Thank you to Panel & List, Nud Collection, and Lundell & Zetterberg for generously sponsoring materials.

Hashem Omar — without you, it would all have turned out flat, quite literally. Thank you!!

Helen Runting, without you this report would still be unwritten - thank you!

A warm thank you to my supervisor, Kristina Fridh, for your patience, wise advice, guidance, and above all your constant encouragement throughout this project.

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Background

For nearly two thousand years, paper has been one of humanity's most important materials for communication, documentation, and knowledge transfer. It has carried letters, books, drawings, contracts, and personal histories across generations. However, during the late twentieth century and into the digital age, many of paper's everyday functions gradually began to disappear. Email replaced letters. Social media replaced printed cards and physical invitations. Screens increasingly became the surfaces through which information moved. As a result, paper slowly began to lose its position as a necessary everyday material.

At the same time, paper has always been more than a surface for writing. It is a material with physical properties: fiber, density, texture, weight, translucency, and structural behavior. It can be folded, layered, compressed, shaped, and transformed. Despite this, our understanding of paper remains strongly connected to its role as a flat surface. This tension became the starting point of this project.

What happens if paper is no longer approached as a medium for information, but as a material capable of defining space, atmosphere, structure, and form? What happens if paper is left unwritten?

Within interior architecture, materials are often selected according to systems of efficiency, predictability, repeatability, and industrial production. Standardized materials offer technical reliability and economic control, but they can also create limitations in how material expression is explored.

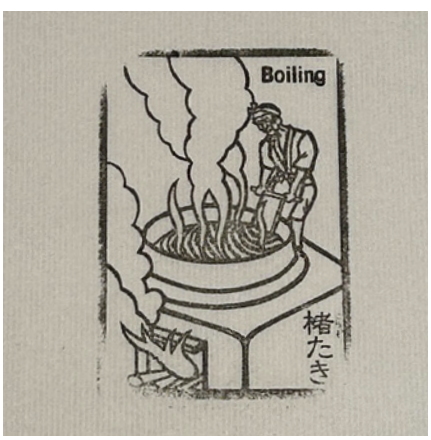
Handmade paper exists outside of many of these industrial systems. Unlike machine-produced materials, handmade paper carries visible traces of process, labor, time, and human decision-making. Variations in fiber distribution, surface texture, thickness, and translucency are not flaws, but integral parts of the material.

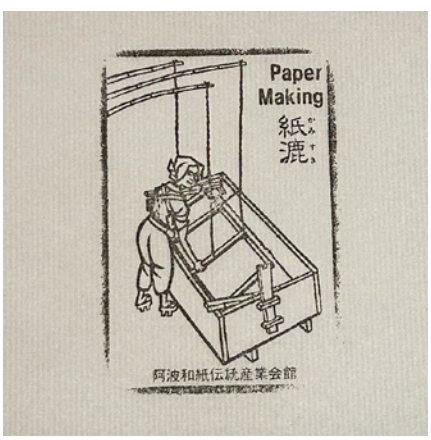
Historically, craft and spatial design were closely connected. Material knowledge was developed through direct contact with processes of making. Trial and error, adaptation, and embodied learning formed an essential part of production. With industrialization, many of these relationships changed. Material production became increasingly separated from design processes, and knowledge that had previously been developed through making became replaced by standardized systems of production. Within this context, handmade paper becomes interesting not only as a material, but as a method of thinking through design.

Japan and Sweden

Handmade paper has long traditions in both Japan and Sweden, though the material has evolved in different cultural and environmental contexts.

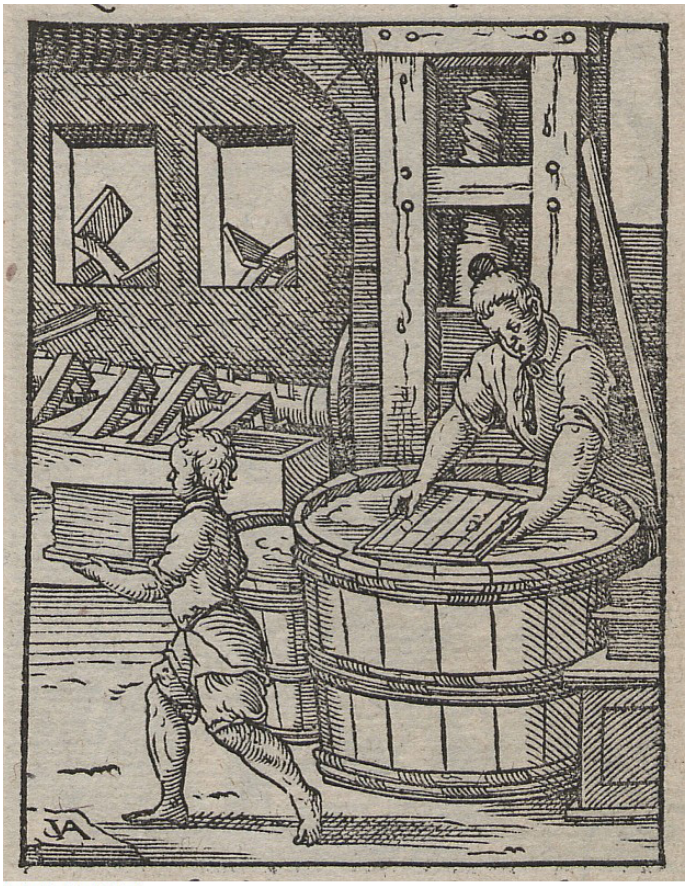
In Japan, *washi* has been produced for over a thousand years and continues to influence architecture, interiors, and craft traditions. Its long plant fibers create a material that combines strength with lightness and translucency. *Washi* has historically been integrated into architecture through elements such as *shoji*, where paper functions not simply as a covering, but as an active spatial element shaping light, privacy, atmosphere, and movement.







Stamps on *washi,* showing the process of *washi* making.
Collected from my field trip to Echizen - Takefu oct. 2025.



Stamp showing the production of a Handpaper Mill in Germany. Looks similar to the one in Lessebo.

Photo: Weigel, C. (1698) *Der Papierer, Papierhändler und Papiermacher* [Online image]. Available at: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Fotothek_df_tg_0002100_Ständebuch_^_Handwerk_^_Handel_^_Papierer_^_Papierhändler_^_Papiermacher.jpg (Accessed: 2 April 2026).

In Sweden, handmade paper has historically developed through different material conditions. Cotton and linen fibers have traditionally been used, often sourced from recycled textile materials. Swedish handmade paper tends to be thicker and more opaque, creating different tactile and structural possibilities.

Today, only one commercially operating handmade paper mill remains in Sweden: Lessebo Handpappersbruk. Founded in 1693, Lessebo represents a long and uninterrupted tradition of handmade paper production. Despite this history, handmade paper occupies only a limited role within Swedish interior architecture.

In *The Craftsman*, sociologist Richard Sennett describes craftsmanship as a form of knowledge developed through practice, repetition, and long-term engagement with a material (Sennett, 2008). Rather than separating thinking from making, he argues that skill is built through an ongoing dialogue between hand and material. This understanding of craft is reflected in the work at Lessebo Handpappersbruk, where papermaking techniques have been preserved and refined across generations.

This project is partly rooted in a personal relationship to this place. Lessebo is located approximately 35 kilometers from the city where I grew up. Its physical closeness made the material feel both familiar and strangely overlooked.

Purpose and Aim

The purpose of this project is to investigate handmade paper as a spatial material within interior architecture.

Through craft-based practice, material experimentation, and spatial prototyping, the project aims to explore how the tactile qualities, structural behavior, and cultural knowledge embedded in handmade paper can generate alternative spatial expressions.

By working between Japanese and Swedish papermaking traditions, the project examines how craft knowledge, cultural context, and slow production processes can inform design practice.

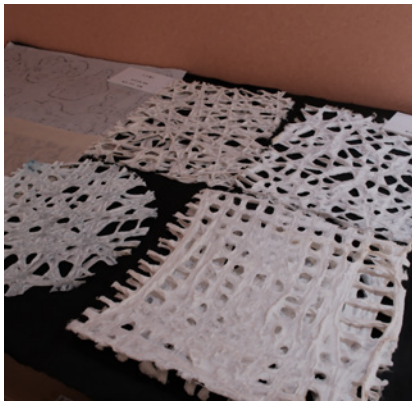
Research Question

The project is guided by the following question: How can handmade paper function as a spatial material in interior architecture?

To explore this, the project focuses on three intentions:
- To investigate handmade paper as a primary spatial, tactile, and atmospheric material.
- To explore how craft-based knowledge and tradition can inform interior design.
- To examine how material-led and slow production processes can challenge industrially standardized spatial expressions.














Inspiring photos taken in Japan, showing washi used on various scales and applied to different objects.

DESIGN PROCESS

Field Study in Japan

In October 2025, I traveled to Japan to study traditional papermaking and to better understand how paper functions not only as a material, but as part of architectural and cultural traditions. The journey became an important starting point for the practical and conceptual development of the project.

Echizen-Takefu

My first destination was Echizen-Takefu, located in Fukui Prefecture. The area is one of Japan's oldest and most important centers for *washi* production, with a papermaking tradition dating back approximately 1,500 years. Even today, the region remains deeply connected to paper production, with dozens of workshops and mills still active in the area. Papermaking in Echizen developed as a year-round craft rather than a seasonal activity, which contributed to the area becoming one of Japan's most established *washi* regions.

Arriving in Echizen gave an immediate sense that papermaking here is not only an industry, but something deeply embedded in the identity of the place. The village itself is surrounded by mountains, rivers, and forests—landscapes that historically provided the clean water and plant fibers necessary for paper production. What stood out most was how closely the workshops were connected to their surroundings. The making process did not feel separated from nature or daily life, but rather integrated into it.

During my time in Echizen, I visited workshops where papermaking knowledge is still passed down through generations. Observing the process up close created an understanding of how much precision, rhythm, and embodied knowledge is involved in each stage of production. Movements that initially appeared simple revealed themselves to be highly controlled and developed through years of repetition. The relationship between the maker, the water, the fibers, and the tools became visible in a way that is difficult to understand through documentation alone.

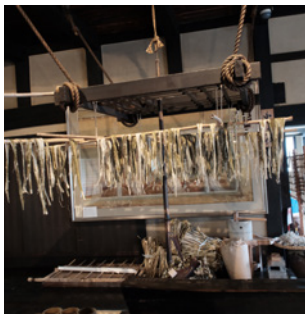
What also became clear was the diversity of the material itself. *Washi* was not presented as one single type of paper, but as a material capable of endless variation depending on fiber composition, thickness, layering, drying methods, and intended use. This challenged my own preconceptions of paper as something standardized and reinforced the idea that paper could be approached as a spatial material rather than simply a surface.



Location of Echizen - Takefu.


JR
福井
ふくい Fukui



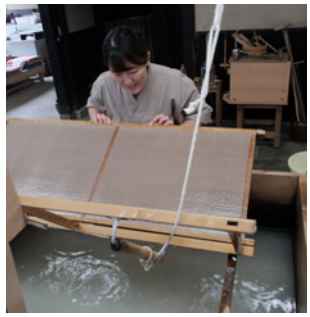










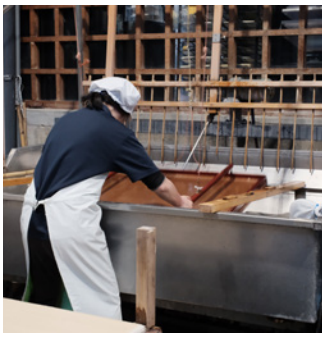







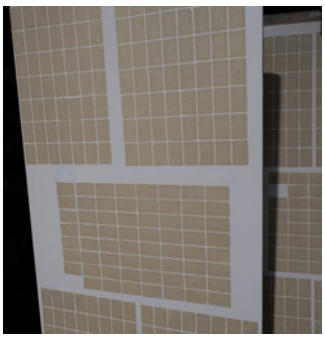

Awagami
Factory
阿波和紙

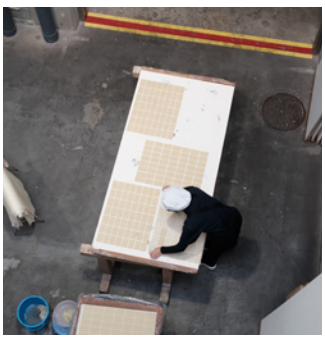















Awagami Factory

The next destination was Awagami Factory in Tokushima. The factory has been producing handmade paper for over 300 years and remains family-run across multiple generations. Here, I encountered a different relationship between tradition and innovation. While the production methods remained rooted in traditional craftsmanship, there was also a clear openness toward experimentation and contemporary applications of paper. The factory is operated by the Fujimori family, whose papermaking tradition spans eight generations.

At Awagami, traditional handmade processes coexisted with more experimental approaches to scale, application, and design. This was particularly inspiring because it demonstrated that traditional craft does not need to exist only as preservation of the past, but can actively evolve and adapt to contemporary contexts.

Seeing handmade paper positioned between craft, art, architecture, and industrial applications expanded my understanding of what the material could become. Rather than treating tradition as something fixed, Awagami showed how historical knowledge can become a foundation for experimentation.

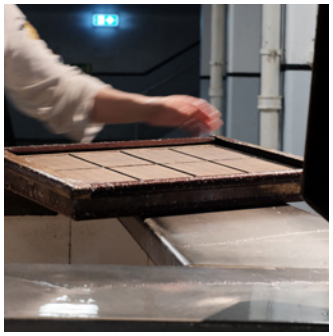
One of the strongest impressions from both places was the shared respect for process and time. Production was not centered around speed or efficiency, but around sensitivity to material behavior. Drying times, humidity, fiber quality, and water content all directly influenced the final result. This material awareness became highly influential for my own process later in the project, particularly when working with paper pulp in sculptural and three-dimensional forms.

Together, the visits to Echizen and Awagami established an important foundation for the project. They shifted my understanding of paper from being primarily a thin surface to being a material with structural, spatial, and atmospheric potential.



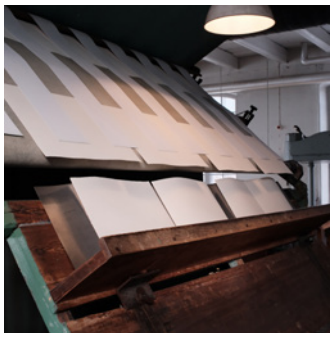
Location of Awagami Factory.



















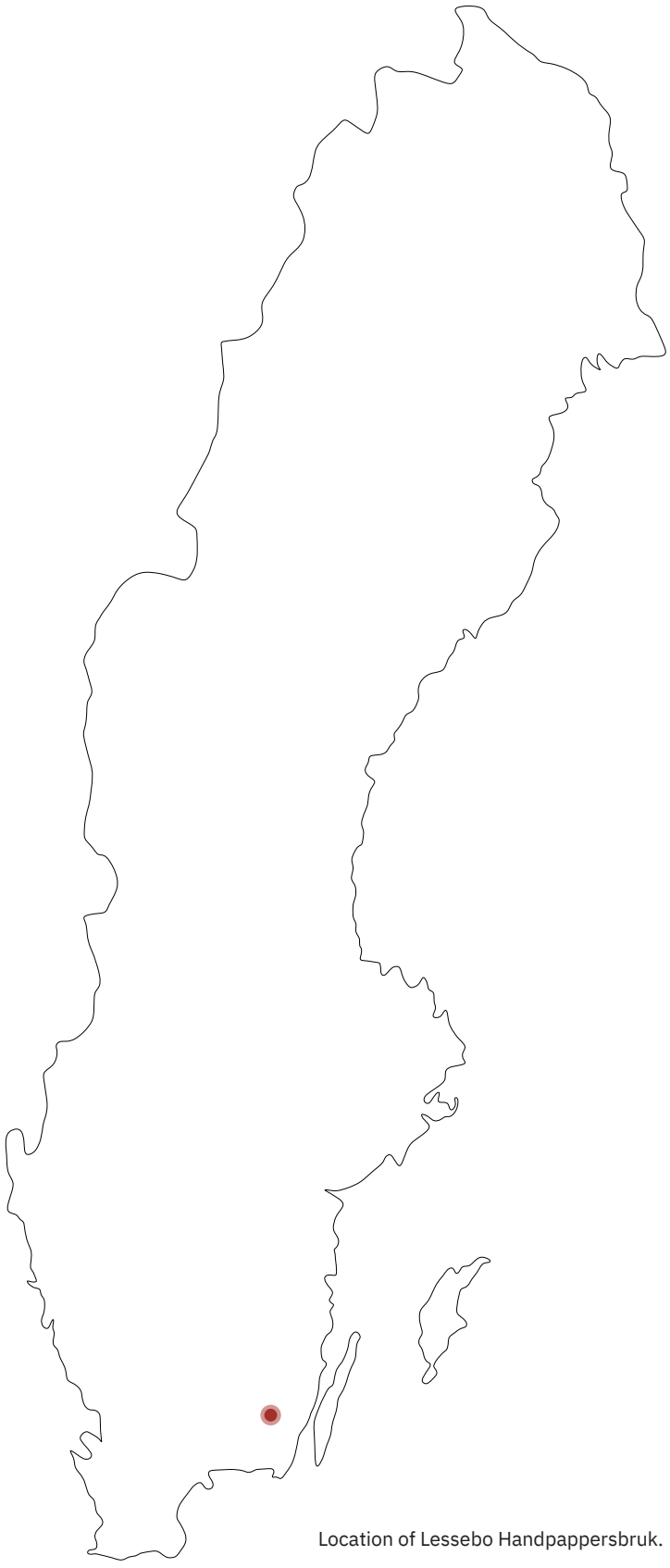
Photos: Isolde Berg and Rebecca Kronlund.

Lessebo Handpappersbruk

Lessebo Handmade Paper Mill is one of Sweden's oldest paper mills, with a history dating back to 1693. The site originally operated as an ironworks, but production was later converted to papermaking in response to the demand for paper products from the naval base in Karlskrona. In 1697, the mill produced its first writing paper with a watermark, and in 1719 it received official privileges from the Swedish Board of Trade, granting permission to manufacture paper (Lessebo Handpappersbruk, n.d.).

The introduction of a paper machine in 1836 marked the beginning of industrial paper production at Lessebo. At the same time, the mill continued its traditional handmade paper production, preserving techniques that are still used today. The mill produces a variety of handmade papers, including writing paper, watercolor paper, and ceremonial documents featuring custom watermarks (Lessebo Handpappersbruk, n.d.).

Today, Lessebo Handmade Paper Mill operates in a stone building constructed in 1897 on the historic mill site. The paper is still made by hand using traditional methods and natural raw materials such as cotton and linen. Each sheet is individually formed by skilled papermakers, making the mill an important example of Sweden's industrial heritage and craftsmanship traditions (Lessebo Handpappersbruk, n.d.).



Location of Lessebo Handpappersbruk.

The Material and its Sustainability

Sustainability is embedded in the material itself. The cotton fibers used in this project originate as a by-product of the Spanish textile industry and were first transformed into handmade paper at Lessebo Handpappersbruk. During production, paper is often made in standard sheet sizes and later cut down to specific formats, resulting in strips and offcuts that cannot always be used for their original purpose. Rather than being discarded, these remnants are saved and can be reintroduced into the papermaking process. The material used in this project comes from such paper strips, stored in the attic of the mill for many years before being shredded and returned to pulp. Unlike many manufactured materials, handmade paper is not bound to a single form or function; it can be broken down and remade repeatedly. The objects presented here are therefore not the final stage of the material's life, but part of an ongoing process of transformation. In this way, the paper demonstrates a circular approach to making, where value is retained through reuse rather than replacement.

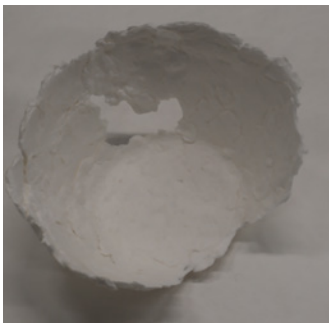
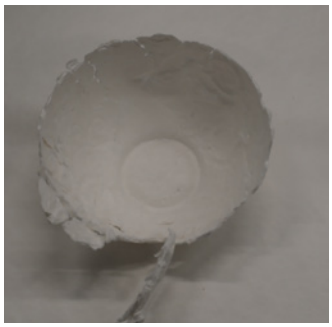
I also chose to work exclusively with unbleached and undyed fibers, keeping the material as close to its original state as possible. Rather than introducing additional pigments or treatments, the natural color of the cotton was allowed to remain visible. This decision was partly motivated by a desire to reduce unnecessary processing, but also by an interest in highlighting the material itself. By retaining the fibers' natural appearance, the focus remains on the qualities of the paper — its texture, translucency, and structure — allowing the material to communicate its origin and history more directly.

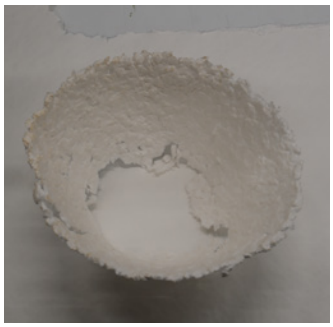






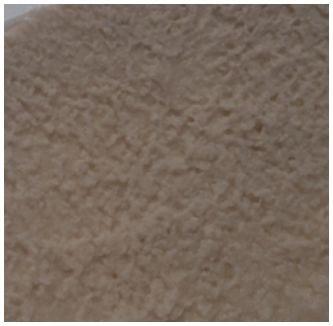

Grinding of the pulp in a Hollander beater (Holländare).
Photos: Rebecca Kronlund.

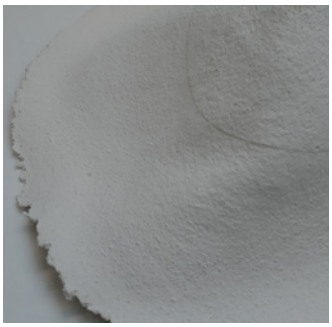


Early attempts to dry paper pulp in a mold. Test conducted at Konstfack using pulp from northern Sweden.






Tests at Lessebo Handpappersbruk: water is squeezed out of the paper pulp, which is then placed on Styrofoam molds.






Tests with a linen and cotton pulp mixture showed shrinkage during drying in the mould.

Material Experiments at Lessebo

After returning to Sweden, the practical phase of the project continued at Lessebo Handpappersbruk. Traditional papermaking at Lessebo follows a structured process involving fiber preparation, pulp formation, sheet formation, pressing, and drying. While this method produces high-quality paper sheets, I became interested in what would happen if the pulp was treated differently.

Instead of forming sheets, I began removing large amounts of water from the pulp until the material could be handled more like clay. This created the possibility of working sculpturally. To support this process, I developed a series of molds using CNC-milled styrofoam. Styrofoam proved to be particularly useful because it does not absorb water, which significantly reduced drying time compared to absorbent materials such as wood or plaster. The low weight of styrofoam also made transportation easier, allowing the molds to be brought directly to Lessebo for testing.

During these experiments, I initially worked with a mixture of cotton and linen fibers. However, as the material dried, significant shrinkage occurred. This led to further testing, eventually resulting in the decision to work exclusively with cotton fibers, which created more stable and predictable forms. The cotton itself carried its own history.

At Lessebo, the fibers I used came from old paper strips stored in the attic of the mill. These fibers had already existed as recycled textile waste, been transformed into paper, and were now being reintroduced into water to become pulp again. This created a material existing in continuous transformation.

Architect and theorist Juhani Pallasmaa argues that knowledge is not only produced through thinking, but also through direct engagement with materials and the act of making. In *The Thinking Hand*, he describes how understanding emerges through a dialogue between the maker and the material, where discoveries are made through experimentation rather than predetermined solutions (Pallasmaa, 2009). This perspective became relevant to my own process, where the properties of the pulp were explored through a series of physical experiments that gradually informed the development of the final objects.

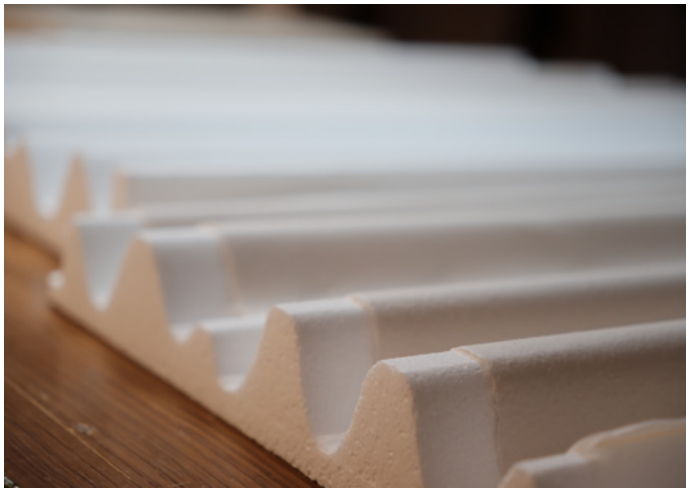
Sheet Experiments

Alongside sculptural molding, I also explored alternative ways of working with paper sheets. Instead of drying sheets flat, I pressed wet sheets between CNC-milled molds to create wave-like surfaces. This allowed the material to maintain its thinness while gaining structural depth.

I also explored pattern-making within the sheet itself before drying. Inspired by techniques observed in Japan, I experimented with adding extra pulp to create irregular textures, as well as applying pressure to generate linear structures. These techniques later informed the final room divider.

Drying, Shrinking, Changing

Working with such a familiar and everyday material in a new way proved to be far more complex than I initially expected. What first appeared to be a simple shift in technique revealed a process dependent on countless variables that needed to align. The behavior of the pulp was not only influenced by form and fiber composition, but also by temperature, humidity, drying time, and the surrounding environment. Working in the uninsulated handpaper mill during January meant that the material dried much more slowly than anticipated, fundamentally affecting the outcome of the experiments. It was also difficult to foresee how significantly the linen fibers would shrink during the extended drying process. These challenges became an important part of the project, revealing how sensitive the material is to both environmental conditions and small changes within the process itself.






The three techniques I explored using the flat sheet. Top: drying in a mold. Middle: splashing paper pulp onto the wet sheet to create a pattern. Bottom: using pressure to create patterns. Photos: Rebecca Kronlund.





Details of the three objects.

Design Proposal

The final outcome of the project consists of three spatial objects: a room divider, a cabinet, and a series of lighting fixtures. Each object presents a different technique developed during the design process and explores a specific spatial potential of handmade paper. Rather than presenting one singular solution, the project proposes multiple ways in which handmade paper can function within interior architecture—as surface, structure, filter, enclosure, and atmosphere.





The Oak

The oak used in this project comes from Blidingsholm, my grandmother Ingrid's family farm in Småland. The trees once stood just outside her childhood home and were cut down by my uncle the year I was born. Decades later, the same material has become part of this project, carrying a personal history across generations.The oak provides stability, weight, and durability, while the paper introduces lightness, translucency, and sensitivity to light. Together, the materials create a balance between strength and fragility, permanence and transformation.



My grandmother’s childhood home; in the foreground, you can see the oak tree that later became the framework for this project.
Photo: Family Archive.

Lighting Objects

The lighting objects developed in this project emerged from an interest in the long tradition of paper lighting in Japan. During the field study, paper repeatedly appeared in relation to light—both in architectural elements such as *shoji*, where daylight is filtered through translucent surfaces, and in traditional paper lanterns used in both public and domestic spaces.

What makes these lighting traditions particularly interesting is how paper functions not only as a surface, but as an active material that shapes spatial atmosphere. When light passes through the fibers of the paper, the material softens and diffuses the light, creating an even and warm glow. This relationship between paper, fiber, and light became an important reference in the development of my own lighting objects.

Traditionally, Japanese paper lamps are often constructed around a structural frame made of bamboo or wood, where thin sheets of *washi* paper are stretched or attached around the form. The translucency of *washi* allows light to pass through the material itself, making the paper an essential part of how the light is distributed in the space.

In this project, I wanted to investigate whether this relationship between paper and light could be approached differently through my own material experiments.

By working directly with paper pulp rather than finished sheets, and by removing large amounts of water from the pulp, the material could be handled more like clay and pressed directly onto three-dimensional molds. Through this process, it became possible to create volumetric paper forms as one continuous surface, without seams, folds, or visible joints. Instead of constructing volume through assembly, the form emerged directly through the shaping and drying of the pulp itself.

At the same time, an important material difference became clear during the process. Unlike traditional Japanese washi, where the plant fibers are significantly longer, the cotton fibers I worked with at Lessebo are approximately one third of that length. This shorter fiber structure affects both the strength and flexibility of the material, making it more difficult to produce extremely thin and translucent surfaces without risking structural instability.

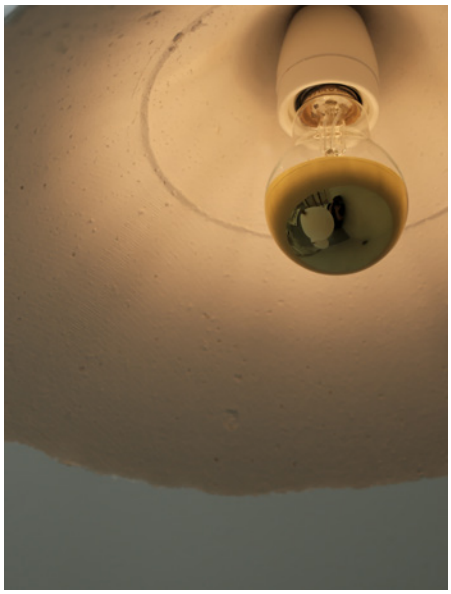
As a result, the paper forms developed in this project became thicker and denser than traditional Japanese paper lanterns. This meant that the material itself no longer allowed light to pass through in the same way as *washi*. Rather than seeing this as a limitation, it became an important design condition.





Over: First tests of drying in molds at Lessebo Handpappersbruk,
a mixture between cotton and linen fibers.
Under: Drying the pulp in CNC-milled molds.








Details of the lamps.

Instead of allowing light to be filtered through the paper surface, the lampshades were designed with an open bottom, allowing the light to spread downward and outward from the interior of the object. In this way, the light is distributed differently, while the paper still contributes to the atmosphere through its texture, volume, and material presence.

This shift demonstrates how differences in fiber structure directly influence spatial and formal outcomes. While the Japanese reference works through translucency and filtered light, my lighting objects respond to the specific behavior of Swedish cotton fibers, allowing the material itself to define a new spatial expression.

Rather than paper being attached to a structure, the paper itself becomes the structure.

In *In Praise of Shadows*, Japanese author Jun'ichirō Tanizaki reflects on the role of light and shadow in traditional Japanese interiors. He describes how materials such as paper screens soften and filter light, creating subtle variations in brightness rather than uniform illumination (Tanizaki, 2001). For Tanizaki, atmosphere emerges through the interaction between material and light rather than through light alone. This relationship between paper, fiber, and illumination became an important reference in the development of my own lighting objects.

Toshiki Hirano and Reinventing Texture

Japanese architect Toshiki Hirano explored the relationship between traditional craftsmanship and digital fabrication in his installation Reinventing Texture, created for the Japan Pavilion at the London Design Biennale 2021. The project combined handmade Japanese washi paper with contemporary technologies such as 3D scanning, CNC milling, and digital modelling to create an immersive wall relief inspired by urban textures from Tokyo and London (Hirano, 2021).

A key aspect of the project was the integration of handcraft and digital production. Hirano collected textures and objects from the urban environment using photogrammetry and converted them into digital models. These models were then used to create CNC-milled polystyrene (Styrofoam) moulds, which served as the foundation for the final forms. The relief panels were produced by manually applying multiple layers of washi paper soaked in glue onto the moulds using the traditional papier-mâché technique. According to Hirano, the process required nearly 200 hours of handwork, demonstrating how digital fabrication and craftsmanship can complement one another rather than exist in opposition (Alt A Review, 2021).

Through this combination of CNC-milled forms and handmade washi surfaces, Hirano reinterpreted traditional Japanese materials for a contemporary architectural context. The project highlights how emerging technologies can be used to preserve and transform craft traditions while creating new possibilities for texture, materiality, and spatial experience (Designboom, 2021; Royal College of Art, 2021).









Photos: https://www.designboom.com/architecture/toshiki-hirano-reinventing-texture-kengo-kuma-experimental-lab-06-08-2021/ (Accessed: 24 April 2026)

The Cabinet

The cabinet was developed as an exploration of how handmade paper can function within a furniture context, not only as a decorative surface, but as an integrated spatial material. While much of the project focused on working with paper pulp in sculptural forms, the cabinet emerged from a desire to continue working with the traditional sheet-making process while challenging its expected flatness. Rather than drying the paper sheets in the conventional way, where the material is pressed and dried as flat surfaces, I wanted to investigate what would happen if the sheets were forced to dry in a three-dimensional form. To explore this, freshly formed paper sheets were placed between two CNC-milled styrofoam molds while still wet. As pressure was applied and the material dried, the paper gradually adapted to the shape of the molds, creating a continuous wave-like surface. This allowed the paper to maintain its thinness and lightweight quality while gaining structural depth and increased rigidity.

What became particularly interesting in this process was how the structural behavior of the material changed through form rather than through added thickness. By introducing curvature and repetition into the surface, the paper became stronger and more stable while still preserving its tactile and lightweight qualities. The geometry itself became part of the material's structural logic. These shaped paper sheets became the defining element of the cabinet. Instead of functioning as a solid front or a conventional cabinet door, the paper introduces a softer and more dynamic interface between the object and the surrounding space. As light moves across the surface, the wave-like forms create shifting shadows, highlights, and subtle variations in depth, making the object visually change depending on its position in the room and the surrounding lighting conditions.

The cabinet is constructed from the same oak as the other furniture pieces in the project, creating a consistent material language throughout the collection. The oak provides structural stability and precision, while the paper introduces lightness, tactility, and a softer material expression. Unlike the room divider, which explores paper as a spatial separator, or the lighting objects, which investigate the relationship between paper and illumination, the cabinet explores how handmade paper can function within a more domestic and functional context. It asks how a material traditionally associated with surfaces, writing, or craft can become part of an everyday object—something that is approached, touched, opened, and lived with. Through the cabinet, handmade paper moves from being observed as a material to becoming integrated into the routines and objects of contemporary interior life.

The three objects presented in this project represent only a few possible ways of working with handmade paper within interior architecture. They are not intended as final answers, but as examples of how the material can move beyond its traditional applications. By approaching paper as a spatial material rather than a surface, the project opens up for further exploration, where the possibilities for future applications remain extensive.





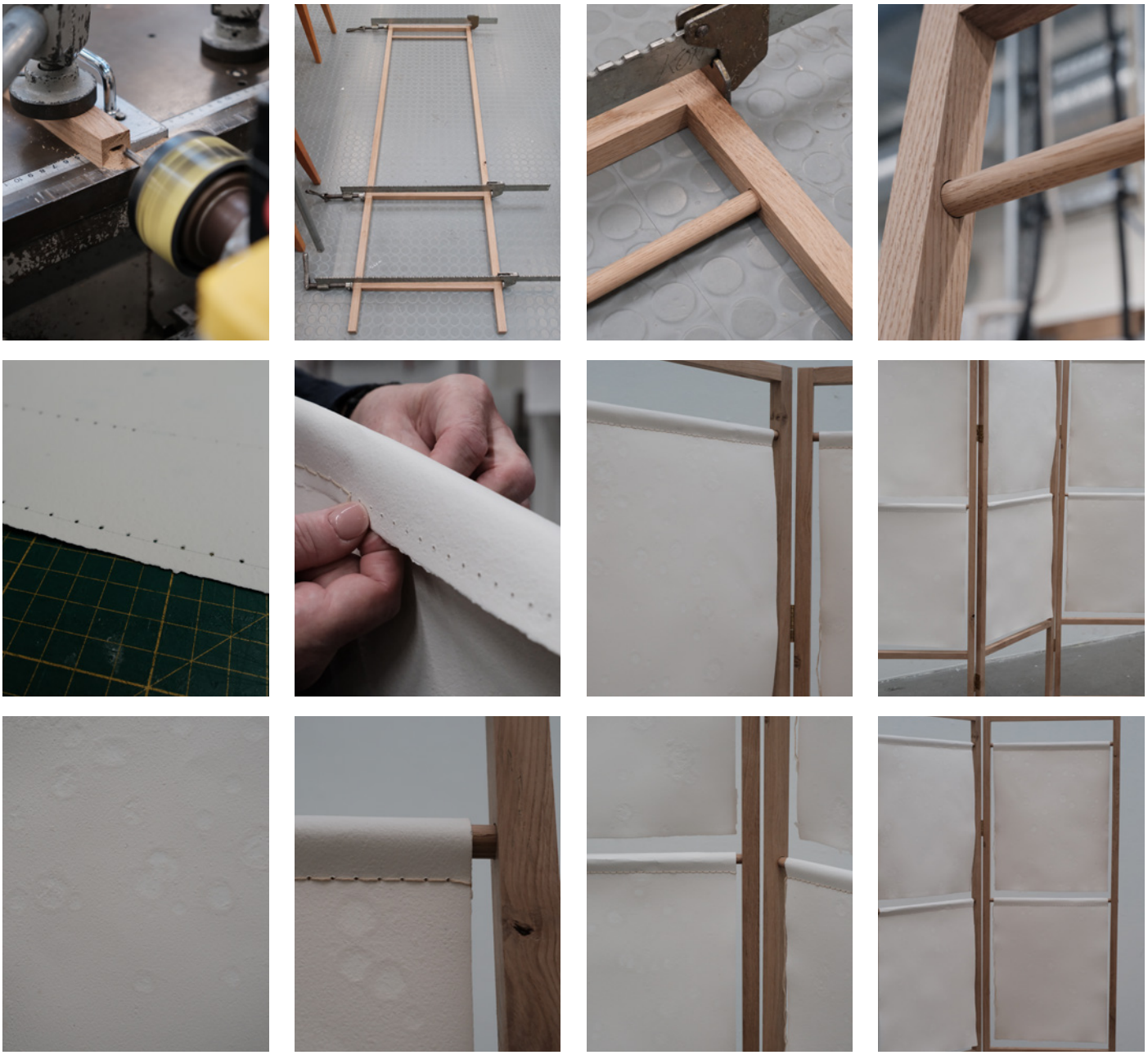









The process of the cabinet.



The process of the room divider.

The room divider

Among these objects, the room divider became one of the most central pieces in the project, as it directly connects the field study in Japan with the material experiments carried out in Sweden.

The divider was developed as a contemporary interpretation of the traditional Japanese *shoji*, a spatial element that became an important reference during the field study in Kyoto. In traditional Japanese architecture, *shoji* are sliding partitions constructed from a wooden frame covered with translucent *washi* paper. Rather than functioning as solid walls, they create soft boundaries between spaces while allowing light to pass through. This creates a spatial condition where separation and connection exist simultaneously. *Shoji* do not completely divide space, but instead create transitions—between rooms, between interior and exterior, between private and public.

During visits to Japanese interiors, I became interested in how these structures influenced both atmosphere and spatial perception. What stood out was not only their visual appearance, but how the paper actively shaped the quality of light within the space. Instead of blocking daylight, the material softened it, diffused it, and distributed it more evenly. This created interiors that felt calm, warm, and materially sensitive. These observations became a starting point for the development of the room divider. Rather than directly reproducing the traditional *shoji*, I wanted to explore what such a structure could become when translated through Swedish handmade paper traditions and through the experimental methods developed during this project.

The paper used in the divider was produced at Lessebo Handpappersbruk using cotton fibers. Instead of applying decoration or surface treatment after production, the patterns were integrated directly into the sheet while the paper was still wet. Through experiments with added pulp and pressure, irregular textures and linear formations were created within the material itself. This allowed the pattern to become an integrated part of the paper's structure rather than something applied onto its surface.

As light passes through the divider, these variations in density, thickness, and fiber distribution become visible. The patterns do not only function visually, but also affect transparency, shadow, and the perception of depth. In this way, the paper becomes an active spatial element rather than a passive surface.

By referencing the spatial principles of the *shoji* while working through Swedish material traditions and contemporary production methods, the divider becomes both a homage and a reinterpretation. It does not aim to copy the Japanese original, but rather to translate some of its spatial qualities—lightness, filtering, layering, and atmospheric presence—into a new material and cultural context. Through this object, paper moves from being something written on to something that shapes how space is experienced.








Different ways to hang the paper.
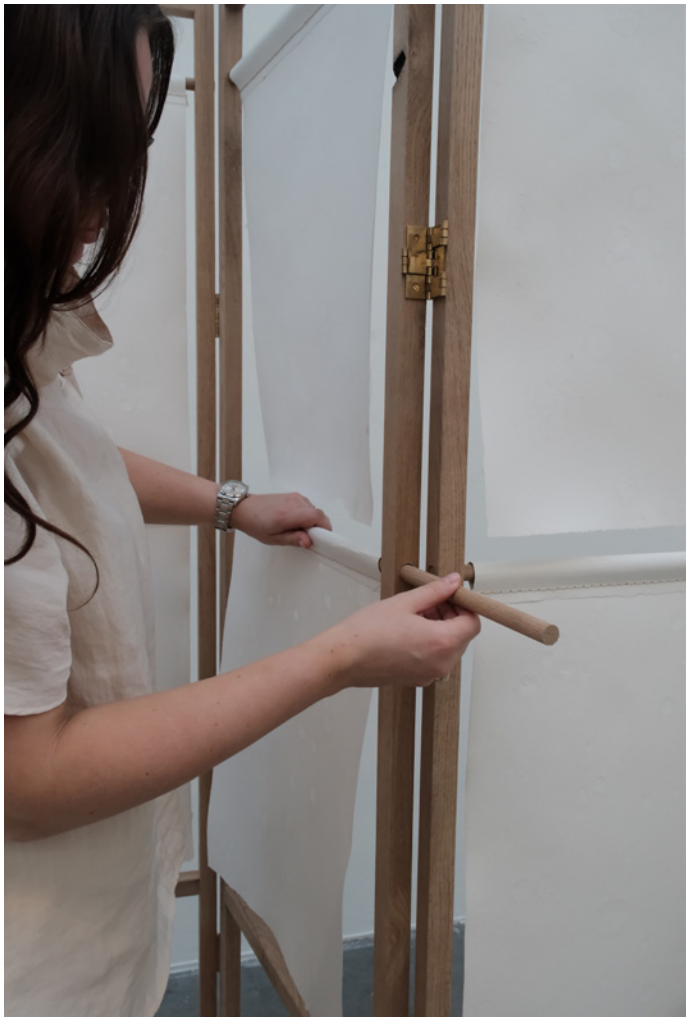
A System for Renewal

The paper elements have been designed to be replaceable, extending both their lifespan and their potential for transformation. In the cabinet, a groove has been cut into the oak frame, allowing the paper panels to be easily inserted and removed. This makes it possible to renew the object over time, replacing damaged sheets or experimenting with different expressions, such as exchanging the wavy paper for flat sheets.

A similar principle is used in the room divider, drawing inspiration from the construction of traditional Japanese *noren* curtains, which are commonly hung in doorways and entrances. In a *noren*, the textile is sewn to create a channel through which a rod can be threaded, allowing it to be easily removed and replaced. In this project, the same technique has been applied to the paper. By sewing directly into the sheets, they can be mounted, removed, and exchanged without altering the wooden structure. The size and proportion of the paper panels can also be varied, making it possible to continuously change the character, transparency, and spatial expression of the room divider.

Although paper is often perceived as a fragile material, the design embraces this characteristic rather than trying to eliminate it. The paper components are intended to be replaceable, allowing them to be repaired, renewed, or reinterpreted over time. At the same time, the supporting structures are made from oak, a durable and long-lasting material capable of outliving multiple generations of paper inserts. This creates a relationship between permanence and change: the oak frame remains, while the paper can evolve, be replaced, and take on new forms. In this way, the objects are designed not as fixed outcomes, but as systems that can adapt and continue over time.





How to pull out the round rod and replace the paper.
Photos: Isabella Werner.



Konstfack’s Spring Exhibition 2026.

The Spring Exhibition

The project was exhibited at Konstfack's Spring Exhibition in May 2026. The cabinet and room divider were presented on plinths, while the lighting objects were suspended from the ceiling. Behind the cabinet, I built a backdrop using the same paper as in the object itself, extending the material beyond the furniture and into the exhibition space. A projection showing the development process, including documentation from Lessebo Handpappersbruk and my research trip to Japan, provided visitors with insight into the project's background and material exploration.

The exhibition became an opportunity to observe how the work was perceived by an audience. Many visitors were surprised to learn that the paper had been handmade as part of the project, often initially assuming it was an industrially produced material. This highlighted both the familiarity of paper as an everyday material and the challenge of communicating the craft and labor embedded within it through the finished objects alone. When conversations turned to the making process, the material itself often became a central point of interest.

One aspect that surprised me was the strong response to the lighting objects, which received more attention than I had anticipated. The combination of spotlights and the lamps themselves emphasized the translucency of the paper and demonstrated how the material could shape atmosphere through its interaction with light. At the same time, the exhibition revealed opportunities for further development. Looking back, additional backlighting behind the room divider would have made the patterns in the paper more visible and strengthened the spatial qualities of the material.

The exhibition therefore became not only a presentation of the project, but also a final stage of evaluation. It provided an opportunity to test how the objects functioned in a public setting and how the material was understood when separated from the making process. While it revealed aspects that could be further refined, it also confirmed the potential of handmade paper to operate as a spatial material beyond the flat sheet, opening up new possibilities for how the material can be experienced and understood.






Details of Konstfack's Spring Exhibition 2026.

Conclusion - Summary and Reflection

This project began with a simple question: what happens if paper is no longer treated as a surface for information, but as a spatial material?

Through field studies in Japan, practical experiments at Lessebo Handpappersbruk, and a material- led design process, this project has investigated how handmade paper can function within interior architecture. By working directly with the material—through sheet formation, pulp casting, shaping, drying, and prototyping—the project has explored how paper can move beyond its conventional role and instead function as structure, enclosure, surface, and atmosphere. The field study in Japan played an important role in shaping the direction of the project. Observing how washi paper was integrated into architecture, interiors, and lighting expanded my understanding of how paper can influence spatial experience through light, transparency, tactility, and rhythm. Traditional elements such as shoji demonstrated how paper can create boundaries without fully separating space, while Japanese paper lighting revealed how fiber structure and translucency can shape atmosphere.

Returning to Sweden, these observations became the starting point for a series of material experiments at Lessebo Handpappersbruk. Through testing Swedish cotton fibers, sculptural pulp forming, and alternative drying methods, the project gradually developed its own material language. Working with Swedish fibers also revealed clear material limitations compared to Japanese washi. The shorter fiber length affected both translucency and structural possibilities, requiring design adaptations rather than direct imitation. Instead of reproducing traditional Japanese techniques, these limitations became opportunities to develop new spatial expressions based on the specific behavior of the material.

The final outcome consists of three objects: a room divider, a cabinet, and a series of lighting fixtures. Each object explores a different technique and demonstrates a different spatial potential of handmade paper. Together, they show how paper can function not only as a visual surface, but as an active material capable of shaping light, structure, privacy, tactility, and spatial atmosphere. At the same time, this project is not only about material experimentation, but also about heritage. Handmade papermaking is built on knowledge passed down through generations, and many of these traditions are becoming increasingly rare. Working with these processes became a way of engaging with that knowledge, not as something static to preserve, but as something that can continue to evolve through design practice.

The three objects presented in this project represent only a small selection of possible applications. Rather than offering final solutions, they function as proposals that open up further questions about how handmade paper can be used in future interiors, furniture, and architectural contexts. A central realization throughout this project has been how much of the material's potential only began to reveal itself through time, repetition, and direct physical engagement. Many of the most important insights emerged through trial and error, failed experiments, and adjustments made during the making process. Looking back, I feel that I have only begun to understand the possibilities of working with handmade paper as a spatial material.



The development potential within this field feels extensive. Through this project, I have established a foundation of material knowledge that I did not have at the beginning—an understanding of how fiber composition, water content, drying conditions, form, and structural behavior directly influence spatial outcomes. With this knowledge, I see significant opportunities to continue developing both the techniques and the applications explored in this project.

If given more time, I would have continued testing larger scales, more structural applications, and new ways of integrating handmade paper into architectural and furniture contexts. Rather than feeling finished, this project feels like the beginning of a longer investigation.

Perhaps the most important outcome of this process is not only the objects themselves, but the realization that handmade paper still contains unexplored possibilities—both as a material and as a way of thinking through design. This project suggests that handmade paper still holds untapped potential within interior architecture —not only as a material from the past, but as a material still in the process of becoming.

Something still unwritten.

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